

ALMONTE AND DISTRICT

Town council briefs

The following issues were discussed during the July 9 Almonte council meeting. Deputy-Reeve Terry Gorman and councillor Adrian Foster were absent. The meeting was chaired by Mayor Dorothy Finner.

North York resolution gets support

Council chose to support a motion from the City of North York calling on the Province of Ontario not to take away gross receipts tax now collected by Ontario municipalities from telephone companies for the use of municipal rights-of-way.

Such a move by the provincial government would cost Almonte \$96,000 in revenue, clerk-treasurer Des Houston told council.

Cavanagh wins contract

Thomas Cavanagh Construction has been awarded the contract for the Gore Street reconstruction project. The area company submitted the lowest of three bids — \$66,653.60 plus GST.

Other bids were received from Choctaw Construction and Karson Kartage and Konstruktion, public works committee chair Garry Dalgity announced.

More requests for town hall

Two more local organizations — Chamber of Commerce and Valley Players — have inquired about space at the town hall once amalgamation kicks in Jan. 1, 1998. At that time, it is expected the new municipality of Mississippi Mills' (formerly Almonte Pakenham Ramsay) home base will be shifted to the present Ramsay hall on Perth Road.

Any decision on the future use or uses of the town hall has been deferred to the new council following the November election.

Licence fee increased

In response to a request from the Business Improvement Area board of management, council has agreed to increase the licence fees for anyone who brings a refreshment cart to an auction or special event from out of town. The fee jumps from \$10 to \$50 per day. The BIA had asked for the cost to increase to \$75.

A second request from the BIA was turned down. The board had asked council to up the licence fees for hawkers and peddlers from \$100 for residents and \$150 for non-residents to a flat fee of \$350.

Kings turned down

A request from the Carleton Place Jr. B Kings hockey club to play a handful of games at the Almonte Arena this winter has been turned down.

The team had asked to play three to five games on selected Sunday afternoons. But because local users have requested more ice time for the upcoming season, the town's parks and recreation committee decided it wasn't possible to accommodate the Kings on the dates requested, Mayor Finner said.

Red Cross gets green light for clinic

Council has okayed a request from the Canadian Red Cross Society for free use of the arena surface for a blood donor clinic Wednesday, Aug. 6.

Mural work concerns

The mayor said she has received complaints about the artwork being done by students on the wall of Levi Home Hardware downtown.

After speaking to those involved, however — including building owner Gord Pike, business owner John Levi and teacher Bill Treusch — she said she is confident the work will be done properly and in good taste.

"After speaking to them, I am more comfortable than I was before," she said.

Councillor Garry Dalgity asked if a design of the mural should not be brought to the town for prior approval. But Councillor Janet Brennan explained that because it is on private property and not promoting a particular business, the signage committee has no jurisdiction.

EDC to add Pakenham

The Almonte-Ramsay Economic Development Committee has brought Pakenham into the fold. The township has already committed some money to the EDC and more is expected before the end of the year, councillor Gillis reported.

Century-old Ironworks building set to begin new life as restaurant soon

Owners say Mississippi Ironworks could welcome first customers this week

By Ryland Coyne
Gazette editor

The old Ironworks building along the Mississippi River has had a storied past. But it's the century-old stone structure's future that has its owners grinning from ear to ear.

Terry McDonald and fiancée Shannon Michie have spent the past year working to restore the once dilapidated two-storey building. They now expect to be able to open the doors to their new Mississippi Ironworks restaurant, possibly as soon as this week.

The transformation — from an abandoned eyesore located behind the Almonte Business Centre building to a gleaming jewel along the river — has been a massive undertaking.

"Basically, everything is brand new," McDonald said, during a rare free moment earlier this month. "All there was when we started was the stone walls."

After buying the building back in 1989, the 32-year-old developer put the project aside to pursue other business opportunities. He did some major structural work on the Ironworks three years ago and, having left his previous work, shifted the development into high gear a year ago.

"(It was) sort of full-out, get-it-done construction," he said.

The building's interior was reduced to literally a shell of its former self before interior walls were installed. Even the retaining wall around the building along the river's edge had to undergo major repairs.

"That was a big job," he said.

Major change

What their effort has produced will surprise many who have not taken a close look at the site in recent months. Outside is a spacious patio overlooking the falls bordered by — what else — an iron fence. A second smaller patio is located upstairs.

The tables will include large umbrellas with the restaurant's name shown on the flaps.

Landscape work has turned what was once just a dirty field into attractive flower beds bordered by rail ties.

"There are a few annuals still to put in," Michie said.

There is also parking for up to 20 vehicles, with access to the restaurant site at the Almonte Business Centre off Little Bridge Street.

Inside, patrons will be able to choose from two separate dining areas. The larger area features hardwood floors with an elegant circular bar. In addition to the 17 bar stools, table seating should accommodate as many as 65 people, she said.

The smaller games/pub room, which leads to the ground-floor patio, will include a pool table. McDonald said he expects to offer some musical entertainment as well starting sometime in the fall. And to add a touch of fun, they hope to have a



Ironworks Restaurant owners Terry McDonald and Shannon Michie are all smiles, knowing their dream is within days of coming true.

C.P. Rail time chart for those who might want to watch the trains pass by along the bridge.

Both rooms overlook the water offering beautiful views of the Mississippi as well.

The menu, meanwhile, will feature a wide selection from homemade finger foods to pasta dishes and other entrees.

Through the summer, he expects to hire 20 to 25 employees, 10 of which will work in the kitchen under the guidance of chef Kevin Ralph.

Growing industry

The addition of the Mississippi Ironworks restaurant brings one more up-scale eating establishment to Almonte's downtown. It also marks the revival of a once-decaying stone building. Van Leeuwen's at the Victoria Woolen Mill first opened a few years ago, then Dave and Garry's All-Star Saloon opened its doors in 1996.

McDonald said he hopes the Ironworks will complement the other establishments in the area.

"It gives people more selection," he said, noting the town has yet to reach what he feels would be a saturation point.

"It seems like there are a lot of restaurants in Almonte, but really there's not," he said, adding Carleton Place has a far greater number of restaurants per capita.

And if the old real estate adage 'Location, location, location' means anything, then this business should have it made.

"We're really lucky...we couldn't



Mississippi Ironworks' Ralph Ruhs (left) and chef Kevin Ralph work to put some of the finishing touches to the restaurant's kitchen facility July 4.

get a better place," Michie said.

Nerve wracking

While the end result is impressive, McDonald said the project has not always run smoothly.

"We're really excited...but it's been very, very stressful," he admitted. He and his fiancée have even taken on some hands-on projects, doing much of the finishing work themselves.

And when they haven't been run ragged getting the final touches in place, they've been busy answering

questions and offering tours to curious visitors.

"There's been a lot of interest," Michie said.

Still, with the end of the beginning now in the sight, he and Michie say the experience has been worth it.

"Every day, when you've locked the doors, you're proud of what you've done," she said.

For more information, call 256-7840 or 256-7841.

Watch the Gazette for the Ironworks' official opening later this summer.

Lawn tractor is stolen from shed here

A red Willinghorse lawn tractor was stolen from a shed at 388 Almonte Street July 10. Police have no suspects. Const. Frank Whiting is investigating the theft.

Mischief at store

Almonte OPP are currently investigating a case of mischief at a local convenience store. On July 11, three bricks were taken out of the face of Beckers convenience store on Bridge Street. Const. Frank Whiting is handling the case.

No charges laid in minor mishap

There were no injuries in a minor collision on Union Street. On July 13, Ellis Selhaber, 70, was backing up onto Union from River Street in her 1989 GMC Pickup truck when she collided with a 1988 Dodge pickup parked on Union Street. The Dodge is owned by Karemor Enterprises in Stittsville.

No charges were laid. The investigating officer was Const. Frank Whiting.

No injuries in accident

At 5 a.m. on June 30, a 1987 Toyota Camry failed to negotiate a curve on County Road 17 and entered the south ditch where it rolled over.

The accident occurred two kilometres south of County Road 20. There was major damage to the car,

POLICE BEAT

but the driver, Leonidas Antonakos, 28, of 238 High Street in Carleton Place, and one passenger escaped without injuries.

No charges were laid.

Perth OPP Const. Jon Goobie investigated.

Boat motor stolen

A 20 horsepower Mercury outboard was reported stolen on July 1. The outboard was taken from a boat parked on the shore near a residence on Hamilton Street. The report was taken by phone and no officer attended.

No injuries in minor accident

Two vehicles attempting to turn right collided at the corner of Mill and Main streets on Monday morning, July 7.

According to police, David MacCartney, 62, of Pakenham was making a wide right turn in a 1990 International tanker when his truck hit Barbara Kirkpatrick's 1990 Toyota Corolla. Kirkpatrick, 45, of 295 Maude St., was also attempting to turn right onto Main Street from the inside lane of Mill Street when the collision occurred.

There were no injuries and only minor damages to both vehicles. There were no charges.

Local driver escapes injury

A Ramsay Township driver narrowly escaped injury after swerving his 1990 GMC pick-up truck off the road to avoid hitting a deer.

The incident took place just after midnight, June 21, on Ramsay's Conc. 2, 2.5 kilometres north of County Road 16.

Perth OPP report Leo Larocque, 25, of R.R. 2 Almonte was southbound when the animal crossed onto the road. The driver, who was alone at the time, lost control of the vehicle and ended up in the east ditch.

The truck had moderate damage. No charges were laid.

Const. Carrie Bowes investigated.

Bike stolen from near restaurant

A bike was reported stolen from outside the Superior Restaurant at 10:05 p.m. Friday. The chrome coloured Vagabond bike was unlocked at the time.

Sgt. McIlmoyl is investigating leads.

Stolen vehicle recovered

A 1986 Pontiac 6000 was stolen from Robert Street on May 17.

OPP cautions public about pyramids

ORILLIA — The Ontario Provincial Police (OPP) is cautioning the public that participation in pyramid schemes is illegal.

Officers from the Ontario Illegal Gaming Enforcement Unit have issued Canada-wide arrest warrants for two individuals from The Hague, Netherlands, who operated an illegal pyramid in the Lindsay area. The scheme required an initial investment and prospective participants were told that commissions and/or earnings were dependent upon the participation of other investors.

The scheme, called "Action", involved more than 60 investors who paid \$4,500 (Canadian funds) and were required to recruit two other investors, who were also required to pay \$4,500.

Arrest warrants have been issued for Raymond Julius De Beaveser, 41, and Helcen Alida Zwaving, 34, both Dutch citizens.